

Automated License Plate Reader petition

Background

This petition regards University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign's (UIPD) use of automated license plate readers (ALPRs), especially those ALPRs that are provided by Flock Group Inc. (Flock).

This petition will not argue that privacy is a human right and will not argue any constitutional issues. On the contrary, the petition argues that UIPD's use of ALPRs should be held to the Division of Public Safety (DPS) Manual of Policy and relevant state law. The violations are not the result of a few bad apples, but rather department-wide practices.

The petition proceeds by first laying out matters of fact. The facts are laid out in a hierarchical outline of statements. I wrote supporting statements in the subsequent levels that taken in conjunction entail the parent statement. To deliberate, I suggest that I read each item verbally. If anyone has an objection or reservation, I will pause to discuss.

Then, based on those facts, I propose a policy resolution.

Facts

We, the undersigned Subcommittee, find the following numbered, top-level facts are more likely than not:

1. Other agencies conducted searches directly on UIPD's Flock ALPR data, without the required reporting, in violation of [DPS Policy 429.5.2](#).
 - a. Policy 429.5.2 states, "Another Illinois law enforcement agency may request that the Department search the ALPRS database... An Authorized User shall conduct the requested search. If a match is found, the Authorized User shall transmit a copy of the Reading to the other law enforcement agency and create a record of the shared information in an Assist Other Agency Report"
 - b. Policy 429.1.1 defines "Authorized User" as "A Department member..."
 - c. The policy implies that other agencies are not supposed to conduct searches directly on UIPD's data because they are supposed to go through an Authorized User (member of UIPD) instead.
 - d. The [Flock Transparency Portal for the University](#) states that 422 organizations are currently "granted access to the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign IL PD data."

Sharing Network Data With

Organizations granted access to University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign IL PD data.

Lewistown IL PD

Adams County IL SO

- Note that when the “Champaign PD Chief of Police ordered the removal of access to the local ALPR network by all agencies outside of Champaign County,” their Transparency Portal simultaneously showed a decrease from 317 agencies to 3. Therefore, this field does indeed reflect with whom the data is shared.
- e. I obtained the Flock Network Audit for UIPD from Jan 1 to Jan 15, 2026 in [FOIA 26-1992](#). Each row in the Flock Network Audit shows a search conducted on UIPD’s Flock data by an external agency.
 - [Flock User Manual](#) page 6 states that the “Flock Network Audit” shows “who has searched your [Flock] network from any agency in the Flock system.”
- f. There are 674 organizations in the Network Audit conducting searches on our Flock Network.
 - If the searches by external agencies were going through an Authorized user, then every row would show “University of Illinois” as the Org Name of the search.
- g. The total number of searches is too large to have been conducted through Authorized Users.
 - Let us assume that all searches from the same organization, within the same hour are duplicates. After removing duplicates, there are 29,083 non-duplicate searches in 15 days, which results in approximately 1 per minute 24/7. This figure can be spot checked for ballpark-reasonableness by noting that there are four rows with unique organizations in one minute between noon and 12:01PM on January 1, 2026 (note that noon CST is 6PM UTC).

Org Name	Search Time
Hamilton County TN SO	01/01/2026, 06:00:02 PM UTC
Wilmette IL PD	01/01/2026, 06:00:06 PM UTC
Clark County IN SO	01/01/2026, 06:00:25 PM UTC
Evendale OH PD	01/01/2026, 06:00:53 PM UTC

- h. In FOIA 26-967, I requested all Assist Other Agency Reports for Jan 1 to Jan 15, 2026. In [response](#), VP Nazon wrote that no records could be found.
 - This does not *prove* the records do not exist, but we are using the standard “more likely than not” for these facts.
- 2. Due to the previous policy violations, UIPD’s Flock ALPR data was searched by external agencies for immigration-related purposes.
 - a. I obtained the Flock Network Audit from UIPD from March 20 to March 31, 2025 in [FOIA 26-1082](#).
 - b. UIPD redacted the “Reason” column from their Flock Network Audit for legal reasons, but it has a column for Org Name and Search Time.
 - c. The UIPD Flock Network Audit contains such rows as:

Org Name	Search Time
Mesa AZ PD	03/24/2025, 04:00:40 PM
Florida Highway Patrol	03/24/2025, 12:45:14 PM
Dallas TX PD	03/25/2025, 02:36:46 AM
Texas Department of Public Safety	03/25/2025, 6:35:08 PM

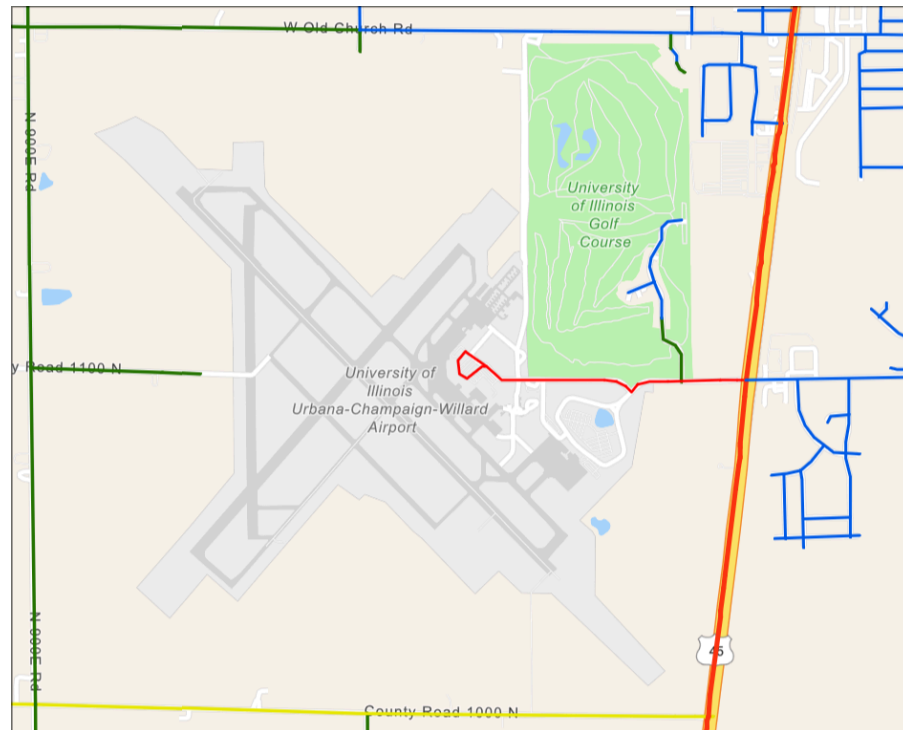
- d. The [Mount Prospect IL Network Audit](#) is available on Muckrock; the Reason field is not redacted. It contains rows such as,

Org Name	Search Time	Reason
Mesa AZ PD	03/24/2025, 04:00:40 PM	immigration violations
Florida Highway Patrol	03/24/2025, 12:45:14 PM	ice administrative warrant
Dallas TX PD	03/25/2025, 02:36:46 AM	ICE+ERO
Texas Department of Public Safety	03/25/2025, 6:35:08 PM	Immigration Status

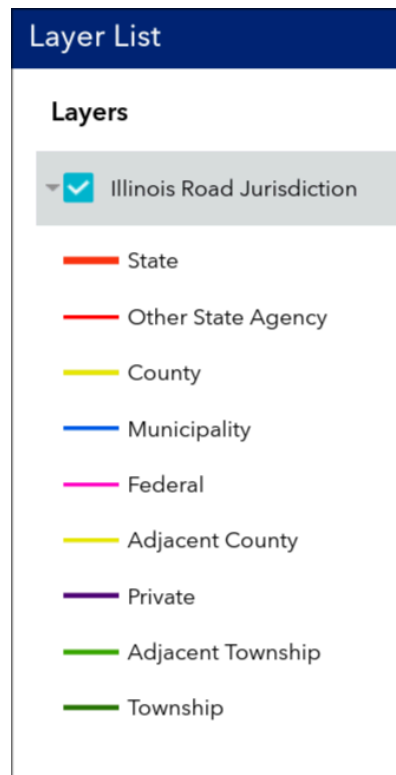
- e. By “cross-referencing” where the organization and search time matches (down to the second), we can infer some of the cells in the “Reason” column that UIPD redacted in their FOIA disclosure.
- For example, the first row states that Mesa AZ searched Mount Prospect and others for the stated purpose of “immigration violations” at 04:00:40 PM.
 - We also know that Mesa AZ searched UIPD at 04:40:40 PM.
- f. In the 11 day time period, of those “Reason” cells we are able to infer, several hundred relate to immigration. I compiled a full table of those rows which match [here](#).
- One can “spot check” a row by finding it in both Network Audits (UIPD’s and Mount Prospects). I suggest using Ctrl+F to find the Search Time.
- g. These records indicate that UIPD gave search access to other departments, including Mesa AZ, Florida Highway Patrol, Dallas TX, and Texas DPS, and those agencies conducted searches on UIPD’s Flock data for immigration-related purposes.
- This chain of events is analogous to what was reported in mainstream media in Danville, Illinois. See 404 Media’s [ICE Taps into Nationwide AI-Enabled Camera Network, Data Shows](#).
- h. If UIPD were following their policy of proxying search requests through Authorized Users, UIPD may have declined to conduct those searches. Because UIPD contrarily gave those agencies search access to UIPD data, those agencies were able to conduct immigration-related searches.
3. UIPD violated the letter or the spirit of the law by allowing the above searches. Nothing in this finding should be construed as implying UIPD *intended* to violate the letter or the spirit of the law.

- a. Note: the University Senate is not a court. The purpose of finding this fact is to motivate changes in policy based on the University's duty to follow the law, not to punish.
 - b. [625 ILCS 5/2-130\(b\)](#) of the Illinois Vehicle Code states "An ALPR user shall not sell, share, allow access to, or transfer ALPR information to any state or local jurisdiction for the purpose of investigating or enforcing a law that... permits the detention or investigation of a person based on the person's immigration status."
 - c. More likely than not, UIPD shared access to ALPR information to other jurisdictions for the purpose of enforcing laws that permit detention or investigation based on immigration status.
4. UIPD has never conducted the ALPR audits, reviews, and evaluations required by [DPS Policy](#) 429.3, 429.5.3, and 429.6.2.
 - a. DPS Policy 429 requires specific audits, reviews, and evaluations to take place.
 - 429.3 states, "Any procedures will include logging access to ALPRS data and periodic auditing of these systems, and random auditing" to "evaluate the compliance of Authorized Users."
 - 429.5.3 states, "The Department will conduct regular data quality reviews and maintenance of ALPRS equipment."
 - 429.6.2 states, "The Captain of Administrative Services or authorized designee shall evaluate the ALPRS at least annually and submit evaluation reports to the Chief of Police and the Vice Chancellor for Administration and Operations [VCAO]."
 - b. I requested the "most recent" of each of the types of audits in [FOIA 26-986](#).
 - c. Vice President Nazon [wrote](#) that after consulting the "Captain of Administrative Services, Chief of Police, and Vice Chancellor for Administration and Operations", and conducting "searches of relevant systems, including electronic files where they believed responsive materials would reasonably be expected to be maintained... No responsive records could be located" (page 2).
 - d. If the person that should have written the evaluation and the two people that should have received the evaluation cannot find the evaluation within a year of its writing, it is more likely that the evaluation never existed.
 - e. I sent VP Nazon's letter to a representative from UIPD and a representative of the VCAO on June 16, 2026, asking for clarification, but none has been offered.
 - f. Due to the initial search finding no responsive records, due to the lack of clarification when asked, due to the ease with which the claim may be negated, the burden of proof is rightly placed on UIPD and VCAO to provide any sort of evidence that the audits *do* exist.
 - g. FOIA response [26-471](#) contains an invoice showing that the University began their contract with Flock for ALPRs on November, 2021, which is more than five years ago.
 - h. More likely than not, UIPD has been out of compliance with 429.3, 429.5.3, and 429.6.2 for the duration of their ALPR program.
5. The University of Illinois placed a license plate reader structure on a state controlled right-of-way without retaining the necessary permit.

- a. According to [IDOT's IL Road Jurisdiction Map](#), Airport Rd. (connecting Willard Airport to US 45) is under state jurisdiction.



b.



- c. [A memorandum from Illinois Department of Transportation](#) regarding “Installation of License Plate Readers within State Rights-of-way” sent on October 5, 2021

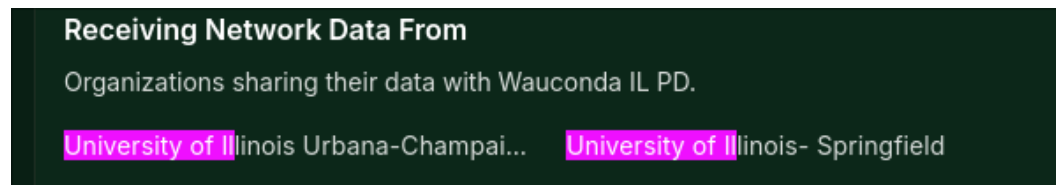
states that “[a]ny LPR installation within state right-of-way will require an IDOT permit. Permit applications shall include: Form OPER 1051, ...”

- d. The University of Illinois placed an ALPR on Airport Rd. and Hartwell according to [FOIA 26-749](#). I photographed this license plate reader. It is on Airport Road and pointed to observe Airport Road.



- e. VP Nazon was unable to find an IDOT Form OPER 1051 for that structure in [FOIA 26-1992](#).
 - f. This fact only alleges that the University does not “retain” the permit. Perhaps it was acquired initially but lost.
6. Deputy Chief Hetrick negligently denied to the Campus Operations Subcommittee that the system is audited while ignoring evidence to the contrary.
 - a. In UIPD’s initial response, Deputy Chief Hetrick said that the audits and evaluations required by policy do exist, stating
 - “UIPD is subject to oversight and auditing by the Office of University Audits” (page 2 of Response to Proposed Resolutions Regarding Flock ALPR Systems).
 - “The proposal... does not present evidence that UIPD has misused ALPR technology or operated outside applicable law or policy.” (page 2, *ibid.*)
 - “In addition to operational, policy, and technology reviews, UIPD is subject to oversight and auditing by the Office of University Audits. These reviews provide an additional layer of institutional accountability and help ensure that departmental practices remain consistent with University policies, applicable laws, and established operational standards.” (page 4, *ibid.*)

- b. I pointed out that the VP Nazon letter states that the audits were not found, writing
 - “Vice President Nazon stated in [FOIA 26-986 on May 11](#) that ‘a search was conducted and no responsive records [audits] were located,’ not even those specifically required by [Division of Public Safety policy](#)” (page 1 of Request for Consistent Narrative).
 - c. Deputy Chief Hetrick, he declined to clarify why he claimed the audits did exist even after learning that VP Nazon was unable to find them.
 - d. The time between the [Request for Consistent Narrative](#) and the UIPD’s subsequent (one month) is sufficient time to act either by conceding, sharing the audits with VP Nazon, or addressing why VP Nazon did not find the audits.
 - e. If Deputy Chief Hetrick has actually located these audits, he could send the missing audits to VP Nazon, a University of Illinois employee tasked with handling FOIA responses.
 - f. Initially writing that the audits exist in the UIPD Response is not necessarily negligent; however, declining to check or retract the statement in the UIPD Denial, without explanation, despite being shown clear evidence to the contrary, is negligent.
 - g. If Deputy Chief Hetrick’s claim were not contested, it may have misled University Senators and the public in a significant way, i.e., that UIPD was maintaining the audits required by policy 429, sections 3, 5.3, and 6.2.
7. When asked about sharing with external agencies, Deputy Chief Hetrick negligently misrepresented to the Campus Operations Subcommittee that all searches by external agencies were going through members of UIPD while ignoring evidence to the contrary.
- a. [Flock Resolution 1](#) stated “several external agencies disclose that they have access to UIPD Flock ALPR data, including Wauconda IL PD” (page 4), accompanied with a link showing the following:



- b. In UIPD’s initial response, Deputy Chief Hetrick wrote:
 - “These provisions reflect UIPD’s requirement that ALPR searches and sharing requests be conducted through authorized departmental personnel in accordance with policy and law” (page 4).
 - “The proposal does not present evidence that UIPD: automatically shares ALPR data... or operates outside applicable law or policy.” (page 11).
- c. Deputy Chief Hetrick never addressed the evidence presented, i.e., that UIPD grants search access to Wauconda IL, in contravention of policy.
- d. It would have been simple for Deputy Chief Hetrick to confirm that UIPD granted search access to Wauconda.
 - According to the Flock Network Audit for March 20 to March 31, 2025, Wauconda conducted 233 searches on UIPD data. There is nothing

special about the time period, which was arbitrarily chosen. It is likely that had Deputy Chief Hetrick searched for Wauconda or any other agency in the Flock Network Log for any month, there would be many records of Wauconda or other agencies searching UIPD's Flock data.

- e. There was sufficient time (two months) between receiving Flock Resolutions 1 and sending UIPD Response to consider the evidence presented and/or search the Flock Network Audit.
- f. In [Request for Consistent Narrative](#), I relayed [FOIA 26-1140](#) response from University Employee Jaimie L. Turpin, showing a list of agencies UIPD grants search access to in Flock, and asked for clarification by July 17.
- g. Without addressing either piece of evidence, Deputy Chief Hetrick declined to amend his statement.
- h. If Deputy Chief Hetrick's claim were not contested, it may have misled University Senators and the public in a significant way, i.e., that UIPD was following sharing policy 429.5.2.

Flock Policy Resolutions

Let UIPD refer to the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign Police Department.
Let DPS refer to the Division of Public Safety.

A resolution declaring lack confidence in ALPR policy compliance

WHEREAS UIPD has more likely than not been in violation of DPS Policy 429.3 for at least the past five years;

WHEREAS UIPD has more likely than not been in violation of DPS Policy 429.5.3 for at least the past five years;

WHEREAS UIPD has more likely than not been in violation of DPS Policy 429.6.2 for at least the past five years;

WHEREAS UIPD has more likely than not violated DPS Policy 429.5.2;

WHEREAS UIPD has more likely than not violated the letter or the spirit of 625 ILCS 5/2-130(b) by sharing data with agencies enforcing immigration laws;

WHEREAS UIPD lacks necessary permits for certain of their ALPR infrastructure;

WHEREAS when students informed UIPD and the Office of the Vice Chancellor for Administration and Operations, UIPD negligently denied one or more of those violations despite being confronted with evidence;

Now be it therefore RESOLVED that the Senate has no confidence in the ability of UIPD to follow policies in DPS policies or state laws regarding ALPR use;

RESOLVED that the Senate has no confidence in the ability of the Office of the Vice Chancellor for Administration and Operations to oversee ALPR use within the boundaries of DPS policy and state laws;

RESOLVED that the Senate urges UIPD and the Vice Chancellor for Administration and Operations to cancel all ALPR contracts for a duration equal to that in which that UIPD was in violation;

RESOLVED that whenever a student, faculty, or staff member files a credible allegation of violation of policy or state statute that is not appropriate for the Formal Complaint procedure, the Office of the Vice Chancellor for Administration and Operations shall issue a public report determining the validity of the allegation within thirty days;

RESOLVED that the same shall apply whenever a student, faculty, or staff member files a credible allegation that a vendor-wide issue reported from in another jurisdiction may have caused a violation of DPS policy or Illinois law.

Code appendix

Download <https://uofi.box.com/s/o3vedl23imxw37v77ijdab09goccxhm0> and adjust "location"

```
import polars

location = "~/Downloads/26-1992 Records 1_1_2026-1_15_2026-University IL
Urbana-Champaign IL PD-Network-Audit.csv"

n_minutes = 1

df = polars.read_csv(location).with_columns(
    polars.col(" Search Time")
    .str.strptime(polars.Datetime, "%m/%d/%Y, %I:%M:%S %p %Z")
    .alias("search_time")
)
print("Time frame:", df["search_time"].min(), "to", df["search_time"].max())

print("Number of external searches:", len(
    df.select(
        polars.col(" Org Name")
        .str.starts_with("University of Illinois")
        .not_()
        .unique()
    )
)
```

```

    )
    .to_series()
))

print("Number of external searches, filtering duplicates:", len(
    df
    .filter(
        polars.col(" Org Name")
        .str.starts_with("University of Illinois")
        .not_()
    )
    .with_columns(
        polars.col("search_time")
        .dt.round(every="1h")
        .alias("search_time_rounded")
    )
    .unique(
        subset=[" Org Name", "search_time_rounded"],
        keep="first",
    )
))

start = polars.datetime(2026, 1, 1, 18, 0, 0)
print("Searchs", df.filter(
    (start <= polars.col("search_time")) &
    (polars.col("search_time") < start.dt.replace(minute=s.dt.minute()+1))
).unique(
    subset=[" Org Name"],
    keep="first",
    maintain_order=True,
).sort("search_time"))

```